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The transnationalisation of Brazilian construction companies

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This chapter attempts a quantitative analysis of the overseas contracts signed by Brazilian heavy civil construction companies from 1969 until the end of the Lula da Silva government.[1] By compiling such information as prices, quantity, geographical distribution, contractors and so on, we see that most contracts are found precisely in regions with priority for Brazilian foreign policy, that is, in South America followed by African countries. On the basis of the research data, we can also establish that movement overseas is extremely concentrated in a few national firms. Thus, we are able to conclude that transnationalisation is a movement typical of large Brazilian capital and depends upon strong state support.

The purpose of the present chapter is to develop a quantitative approach to the international operations of Brazilian heavy civil construction contractors from 1969 to 2010.[2] Since the end of the 1960s, national contractors have been seeking and making contracts for public and private works in other countries, above all in Latin America, Africa and the Middle East and, afterwards, also in Europe and North America. The first international contracts signed by Brazilian construction firms date from 1969. This fact explains our choice for the start of the timeline. As the endpoint of the process, 2010 is justified because it is the end of Lula da Silva's government, a period marked by strong inducements for these companies' operations outside the country.

The introduction of figures and quantitative methods can enrich and facilitate the corroboration of certain interpretations of the historical process and can lend a greater degree of reliability to certain conclusions drawn. But their use comes with